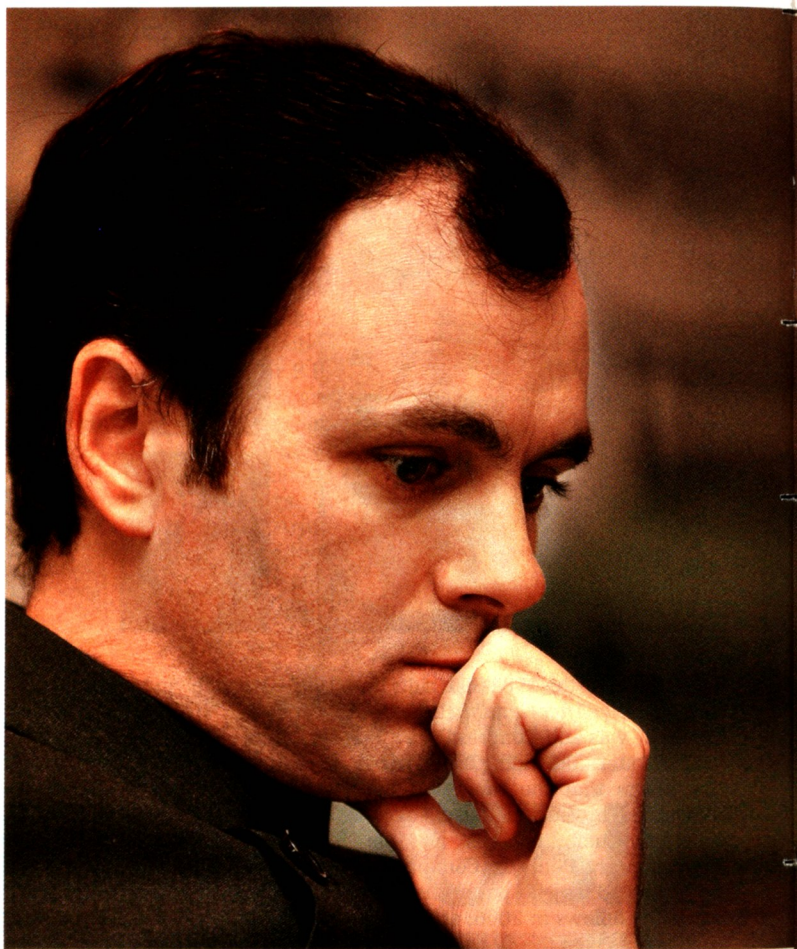


| By Priya Sahgal and Aijaz Hussain |

There is more to being a chief minister than riding a Ducati 999 along the Dal Lake. This is something that Omar Abdullah, the country's youngest chief minister, is fast realising as he steers through some rocky terrain. As the 39-year-old took office early this year, the hopes of the Kashmiri people rode high. Here was a young, clean GenNext politician who had won a credible mandate with an impressive 60 per cent voter turnout. For most, this earnest Abdullah epitomised a new dawn in the strife-torn Valley. He spoke a new language of development, investment and employment, of setting up junta durbars, 24-hour helplines and even a Truth and Reconciliation Commission between J&K and Pakistan-Occupied-Kashmir.

Six months later, as the rhetoric of rape and riots refuses to go away, a weary sense of *deja vu* has crept over the Valley. The mishandling of the Shopian rape and murder case, the Bomai and Baramulla firings has dulled the shine of the Omar era even before it could begin. "Give him time, it's too early to judge him," cautions his father and former chief minister Farooq Abdullah. His opponents are less indulgent. "When Omar took over he said he was fortunate that he didn't face the same situation as his predecessors. Violence was down so he could focus on development," PDP President Mehbooba Mufti told INDIA TODAY. She adds, "But Kashmir is a tough state. You need political acumen and an awareness of the ground reality. Omar has a lot to learn."

Unfortunately, for young Omar, his has been a baptism by fire. The Shopian case could well turn out to be his Achilles heel. When the corpses of the two girls Asiya and Nelofar were found, protesters took to the streets alleging murder and rape by the security forces. At that time, the chief minister was away in Delhi. Yet, he was quick to pronounce this as "a death by drowning". Later, when investigations pointed to rape and murder, Omar set up a one-man commission



Fading GLITTER

The man who started as the Valley's greatest hope is fast turning out to be a huge letdown

under Justice (retd) Muzaffar Jan to look into the matter. "Omar's mistake," points out a Union minister, "was that he treated this like a crime. In J&K any such incident is blown into an anti-India agitation. What was required was a political reaction.

Farooq would have immediately dashed to Shopian, met the families and wept copious tears." Omar, on the other hand, has not yet visited Shopian, a town that still remains shut six weeks after the incident. Stung by the criticism, the normally media